In the wider world that year, Helmut Kohl won the federal elections for the second time in January 1987, prompting Gorbachev to declare his willingness to intensify cooperation ‘at all levels’ in German-Soviet relations, which he considered of ‘central importance’ for future foreign policy. By July, FRG President Weizsaecker was embarking on a state visit to Moscow and issuing a reciprocal invitation (which was realised in June 1989).

This marked improvement in ties between Moscow and Bonn, and led Gorbachev to finally grant Honecker permission to make his often-postponed visit to West Germany. Vyacheslav Kochemasov, the Russian ambassador in Berlin, remembered the SED leader displaying a feeling of contentment and relief when the trip was confirmed, ‘as if the great tension that had prevailed up to that point had been released’. Almost immediately, Volkskammer president Horst Sindermann, was dispatched on a lightning visit to Bonn to firm out details, while exhaustive talks opened over who Honecker would speak with, subjects for discussion, after-dinner speeches; itinerary; and the text of a joint communiqué at the end of the visit.

Soon, unofficial articles of greeting – including one from Helmut Schmidt – appeared in the West German media. Writing in Die Zeit, Schmidt noted ‘even if Erich Honecker, and we can never be friends, in terms of party or politics in general, let us receive him honourably. Receive him as one of our brothers!’11 Likewise, Oscar Lafontaine, the prime minister of Saarland and deputy head of the SPD, noted ‘the SED general secretary as a man who, like all natives of Saarland, was capable of not taking things too seriously’.12